Digit-Sum Reachability on the Lattice: An Experimental Expedition from Brute Force to a Two-Line Criterion

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Abstract

Starting from $(0, 0)$, a walker moves on $\mathbb{Z}^2$ through cells satisfying $\mathsf{s}(|x|) + \mathsf{s}(|y|) \le N$, where s is the digit sum (base 10 unless noted). We chronicle an experimental program on the reachable set: exact counts and the fractal geometry of the region; a Cantor-like staircase in N with cliffs at multiples of 9; an exact closed form in base 2, $Q(N) = \binom{2N+3}{N}$; a carry-free self-similar ("gastank") decomposition giving a polynomial-time exact solver; the asymptotic law reachable/allowed $\sim c/\sqrt{N}$ with $c = 3.84717(5)$ (refuting a tempting $\sqrt{15}$); and finally an exact two-line reachability criterion, proved in a companion paper, which subsumes every structure met along the way and reduces all counting to a one-dimensional walk recursion. We keep the narrative in expedition order, including two instructive false summits.

1 The problem

A cell $(x, y) \in \mathbb{Z}^2$ is *allowed* iff $\mathsf{s}(|x|) + \mathsf{s}(|y|) \le N$; the *reachable set* is the 4-connected component of the origin within the allowed set. Write $f(N)$ for its size and $Q(N)$ for the size of its closed-quadrant part. The canonical instance is $N = 19$:

$$f(19) = 102{,}485, \qquad \text{bounding box } [-298, 298]^2,$$

the box ending exactly at the first *axis cliff*: $\mathsf{s}(299) = 20$ makes the entire column $|x| = 299$ forbidden. The region is 4-fold symmetric, diamond-like at large scale, pierced by rectangular "death zones" and nested self-similar triangular voids.

Allowed versus reachable

Each row y of the allowed set is the one-dimensional set $\{x : \mathsf{s}(|x|) \le N - \mathsf{s}(|y|)\}$, so the allowed set factors through a family of 1-D threshold sets. Counting allowed cells in the bounding box at $N = 19$ gives 166,973, versus 102,485 reachable: a gap of 64,488 cells (38.6%) that satisfy the constraint but are cut off behind carry cliffs — *islands*. The canonical island: $(300, 0)$ is allowed ($\mathsf{s} = 3$) but hidden behind the forbidden column $x = 299$.

*Joint exploration with Claude (Anthropic). Scripts, exact datasets, and the companion proof paper live in the project repository.

2 The staircase in N

Exact counts as N grows show a descending, Cantor-like pattern in the ratio $f(N)$/allowed-in-box, with cliffs exactly at $N \in \{9, 18, 27, 36\}$ — the thresholds at which the box first jumps a decade.

N	$f(N)$	allowed (box)	ratio	box
8	145	145	1.0000	±8
9	505	649	0.7781	±18
17	14,785	18,265	0.8095	±98
18	47,905	73,885	0.6484	±198
19	102,485	166,973	0.6138	±298
26	1,309,537	1,885,501	0.6945	±998
27	4,216,357	7,552,009	0.5583	±1998
35	117,109,345	190,327,945	0.6153	±9998
36	377,329,873	761,526,445	0.4955	±19998

Within each decade the topology is fixed and holes fill in monotonically; each new decade adds an outer, rescaled copy of the previous decade's pattern. The ratio minimum falls two steps *after* each cliff ($N = 11, 20, 29$), not at it.

3 The monotone lemma

A BFS-depth experiment found *detour* := geodesic − $(|x| + |y|)$ to vanish on every reachable cell: whatever is reachable at all is reachable by a monotone staircase. Equivalently, in the quadrant,

$$R(x, y) = \text{allowed}(x, y) \wedge \big(R(x{-}1, y) \vee R(x, y{-}1)\big)$$

reproduces full undirected reachability. Verified for $N \le 22$ (base 10) and for bases 2–5; later *proved* as a corollary of the criterion of §8. Connectivity failures are always total (islands), never partial (no cell requires a detour). Practically, the lemma converts BFS into a vectorized row sweep, ∼100× faster — the workhorse for everything below.

4 Base 2: an exact closed form

In base 2 the quadrant count is a single binomial coefficient:

$$Q_2(N) = \binom{2N+3}{N}, \qquad f_2(N) = 4\binom{2N+3}{N} - 2^{N+3} + 5,$$

verified for $N \le 15$ with the $N = 15$ value *predicted before* a 4.3×10^9-cell sweep confirmed it. The allowed-set side is classical, $\big(4^{N+1} - \binom{2N+2}{N+1}\big)/2$, so the island count is closed-form by subtraction, and

$$\frac{Q_2(N)}{\text{allowed}} \longrightarrow \frac{4}{\sqrt{\pi N}}.$$

The ratio tends to *zero*: there is no finite asymptotic density. Q_2 is OEIS A002054 (ballot numbers), pointing to a lattice-path bijection; the base-10 sequence $f(N)$ is not in OEIS.

5 Gastanks: the carry-free decomposition

Definition 1 (Tank, wall, weir, wetting front)**.** A *tank* $T_k(K)$ is a block $[0, 10^k)^2$ in local coordinates with budget K: local cell (u, v) allowed iff $\mathsf{s}(u) + \mathsf{s}(v) \le K$. Since digit sums are carry-free inside a block, the child at digit position (i, j) is exactly $T_{k-1}(K - i - j)$: budgets step down by one per digit, with no corrections, ever. A *wall* is the trailing-nines seam between sibling tanks (digit-sum cost $9s$ at sibling scale s); carries *are* walls. A *weir* is the passable part of a wall, $\{v : \mathsf{s}(v) \le K_{\text{left}} - 9s\}$ — itself a 1-D threshold set one scale down. A *wetting front* is the set of edge cells through which flow passes; fronts are Cantor-dust-like with up to $\sim 9^{k-1}$ intervals.

Equivalently, in *terrain* coordinates (elevation = $\mathsf{s}(x) + \mathsf{s}(y)$, waterline = N): walls are ridges, weirs are notches dipping below the waterline, islands are submerged basins sealed off by ridges that never dip.

Flooding tanks recursively — passing fronts over weirs, with fronts hash-consed as interned 10-tuples of child fronts (a DAG; never expanded) — gives an exact solver whose distinct-state count grows only polynomially ($\sim N^{3.3}$). Benchmarks (cold start, cross-checked outputs):

N	BFS (set)	BFS (grid)	monotone DP	tanks	$f(N)$
26	1.31 s	1.19 s	0.009 s	0.002 s	1.3×10^6
28	—	8.55 s	0.053 s	0.003 s	9.0×10^6
36	—	—	1.98 s	0.008 s	3.8×10^8
90	—	—	—	0.13 s	2.5×10^{20}
360	—	—	—	16.2 s	$\sim 10^{89}$
630	—	—	—	144 s	$\sim 10^{140}$

The first three methods are all $O(\text{area}) = O(10^{2N/9})$; the tank solver is polynomial in N. Per residue N mod 9, the sequence Q is neither C-finite (order ≤ 13 excluded) nor holonomic within order ≤ 6, degree ≤ 8 — but the *allowed* count fails identically, so base 10 lacks base 2's central-binomial collapse rather than being intrinsically wilder.

6 The constant c: two false summits

On the *peak line* $N \equiv 8 \pmod 9$ (box = bounding box), set $c_N = \sqrt{N} \cdot \text{reachable}/\text{allowed}$.

False summit 1: $\sqrt{15}$. Pair extrapolations through $N = 629$ landed within 1.3×10^{-5} of $\sqrt{15} = 3.87298$. But exact data to $N = 989$ (tank solver, 15M states) showed c_N *cresting* at 3.86931 near $N \approx 650$ and then descending with accelerating increments — $\sqrt{15}$ exceeds every value ever attained. The agreement was a crossing artifact of two competing correction terms.

False summit 2: $c = 3.865 \pm 0.004$. With data ending at $N = 989$, model fits (calibrated on base 2, where naive $1/N$-polynomial extrapolation misses $4/\sqrt{\pi}$ by 2×10^{-2}) gave 3.865(4). The criterion of §8 later allowed evaluation at $k = 16{,}000$ ($N = 143{,}999$): the descent continues far past the old horizon, and

$$c = 3.84717(5)$$

— precisely where earlier "degenerate" power-law fits had pointed. The crest and both correction families (a geometric-per-decade term with ratio ∼0.91 and a slow power tail) are finite-k features of one exact model. Bases 3, 4, 5 show the same crest-then-descend shape; base 2 ($c_2 = 4/\sqrt{\pi}$, approach from above) is the degenerate case.

7 The spectral expedition

Instrumenting the flood recursion and normalizing tank states as (depth, d, front classes) with $d = 9k - K$ (offset of the waterline from the tank's mean elevation) yields, empirically:

1. **Exact fixed point.** The shallow census is *identical* — integer-for-integer — across all peak-line N tested (116–404), at every instrumented depth. All N-dependence lives in the deepening diffusive interior.

2. **Closure.** Transition profiles are well-defined functions of truncated front signatures (577/651 classes unambiguous; failures only at deeply submerged $d \leq -35$); classes per offset saturate at 24. The active band is one-sided: no active tank has $d > 1$.

3. **Spectrum.** The truncated transfer matrix gives $\lambda_1 \to 95.2$ (toward the trivial 100) and λ_2/λ_1 rising $0.58 \to 0.78 \to 0.86$ with truncation depth, toward the observed per-decade correction ratio ~0.91 — data-limited, not trend-limited.

The d-walk steps by $(i + j) - 9$ per scale: a Markov-additive process whose continuum spectrum is the power-law correction family of §6.

8 The reachability criterion

A scalar Wiener–Hopf "warm-up" — modelling reachability as the d-walk surviving below the census barrier $d \leq 1$ — reproduced base 2's constant to 4×10^{-5} with no fitted parameters. Testing whether the model is *literally* true:

Theorem 2 (Reachability criterion; proof in the companion paper)**.** *In base b, threshold N, $k = \lfloor N/(b-1) \rfloor + 1$: a quadrant cell (x, y) is reachable iff every proper digit-prefix pair (lengths $1 \leq s < k$) satisfies*

$$\mathsf{s}\big(x\langle s\rangle\big) + \mathsf{s}\big(y\langle s\rangle\big) \;\leq\; N - (b-1)(k-s) + 1,$$

and $\mathsf{s}(x) + \mathsf{s}(y) \leq N$.

Zero mismatches against exhaustive reachability across bases 3, 5, 10; integer equality with the tank solver's $Q(N)$ up to $N = 989$. The proof is elementary: *necessity* because any entry into a cell's scale-m ancestor tank crosses a trailing-nines wall, entries from the left/below certifying the *neighbor's* wall — one digit cheaper via $\mathsf{s}(X) \leq \mathsf{s}(X-1) + 1$, whence the +1 slack; *sufficiency* by an explicit L-path to the ancestor tank's corner — worst cells $(a-1)\underline{9\cdots9}$ and $a + (c-1)\underline{9\cdots9}$, allowed exactly under the criterion bound — followed by recursion inside the tank at threshold $N - a - c$. The two +1's coincide; the criterion is sharp. The monotone lemma follows as a corollary.

Consequences: counting reduces to a 1-D walk recursion ($O(k^2 b)$ — microseconds at any N); the constant c is a one-boundary survival constant of the centered tent walk, i.e. a kernel-method/Wiener–Hopf object with an explicit (if unlovely) analytic characterization; and the 24-class front dynamics of §7, while real as 2-D geometry, is count-irrelevant — reachability depends only on ancestor budgets.

9 Open problems

1. Extract c_b in closed analytic form from the Wiener–Hopf factorization of the tent kernel; verify $c_{10} = 3.84717(5)$ and the per-decade ratio ~ 0.91 from the factorization's subleading singularity.
2. A reflection-style bijection proving $Q_2(N) = \binom{2N+3}{N}$ from the criterion's interleaved-bit walk.
3. The full two-dimensional geometry (which cells flood *within* a tank) retains the 24-class transfer structure; characterize its fixed point.
4. Submit $f(N)$ (and the peak-line Q data) to OEIS.